

The 3 Empathy Model with Questions and Tools (Green Spectrum)

1. BUSINESS EMPATHY

Focus: Strategy, finance, operations, competitive positioning, risk, regulatory readiness, value creation

A. Strategic Alignment and Positioning

Questions:

- What are our core strategic objectives, and how do they align with sustainability imperatives?
- What is our business's current sustainability ambition or aspiration?
- How would a regenerative strategy shift our market position?
- What disruptions or opportunities are emerging in our sector due to sustainability shifts?

Tools:

- Playing to Win Strategy Cascade
- PESTLE and STEEPV Analysis
- Scenario Planning and Three Horizons
- Strategic Assumptions Mapping
- ESG Benchmarking (SBTi, B Corp, GRI, CDP)
- Strategic Risk Radar

B. Value Chain Mapping and Leverage

Questions:

- What does our current value chain look like?
- Where are the high-impact, high-risk, or high-leverage nodes?
- Which activities are most resource-intensive or vulnerable to disruption?
- How can we redesign parts of our value chain for resilience and sustainability?

Tools:

- Value Chain Mapping
- Systems Mapping (process and stakeholder levels)
- Supply Chain Flow and Emissions Mapping
- Regenerative Business Model Mapping
- Materiality Mapping

C. Business Model and Financial Implications

Questions:

- Which of our current revenue streams or services are at odds with sustainability goals?
- What are the financial opportunities in sustainable innovation?
- What is the cost of inaction on ESG issues?
- What ROI can we expect from sustainability-driven transformation?

Tools:

- Business Model Canvas
- Flourishing Business Canvas
- Cash Flow Analysis and Value Driver Trees
- Cost-Benefit Analysis
- Environmental Profit and Loss (EP&L)
- Monte Carlo Simulation for Risk and Return
- Opportunity Portfolio Mapping

D. Regulatory and Compliance Landscape

Questions:

- What current or upcoming regulations will affect our operations (e.g. CSRD, CBAM, ISSB)?
- Are we prepared for ESG disclosures and double materiality?
- What data systems are needed to comply with emerging standards?

Tools:

- PESTLE with Regulatory Lens
- ISSB/CSRD Diagnostic Checklists
- ESG Reporting Dashboards
- Compliance Audit Tools
- ESG Risk Heatmap

E. Benchmarking and Sector Comparison

Questions:

- What are other leading firms doing in our industry?
- How do we compare on ESG maturity and innovation?
- Where do we have opportunities for leadership?

Tools:

- Industry Benchmark Reports (CDP, SBTi, UNGC)
- ESG Performance Scorecards
- Sustainability Maturity Models
- Competitive Sustainability Positioning Matrix

2. HUMAN EMPATHY

Focus: Culture, leadership, employee motivation, skills, behaviour, inclusion, internal power dynamics

A. Leadership, Governance and Influence

Questions:

- Who owns sustainability in our organisation?
- What are the mindsets, values, and incentives of leadership regarding sustainability?
- Who are the informal influencers, champions, and resisters of change?

Tools:

- Power and Influence Matrix
- Organisational Network Analysis (ONA)
- Leadership Alignment Interviews
- Strategic Narrative Mapping
- Systems Thinking Culture Mapping

B. Employee Culture, Attitudes, and Resistance

Questions:

- What do staff believe about sustainability and their role in it?
- How do people understand or misunderstand ESG?
- What emotional barriers (apathy, fear, distrust) exist?
- Are staff rewarded or disincentivised for initiating change?

Tools:

- Cultural Iceberg Analysis
- Change Readiness Assessment
- Staff Survey Design (quantitative and qualitative)
- Sensemaking Interviews
- Behavioural Insight Mapping
- Systemic Inquiry into Organisational Rituals

C. Skills, Capability and Learning Readiness

Questions:

- What sustainability skills already exist across teams?
- What are the most urgent skill or knowledge gaps?
- What role-specific training or support is needed?

Tools:

- Green Skills Audit
- Capability Maturity Mapping (by role or function)
- Training Needs Analysis
- Stakeholder-Role Learning Canvas
- Skills-to-Impact Matrix

D. Internal Innovation and Co-creation Potential

Questions:

- Are employees invited to contribute sustainability ideas?
- How is innovation managed, surfaced, or blocked internally?
- What cross-functional collaborations are already happening or possible?

Tools:

- Innovation Readiness Canvas
- Change Sprint Frameworks
- Co-design Workshops (double diamond, design sprint)
- Psychological Safety Mapping

- Idea Lifecycle Tracking

E. Stakeholder Engagement and Inclusion

Questions:

- Who are the critical stakeholders (internal and external)?
- What values, expectations, or needs do they hold?
- Where are there blind spots in stakeholder representation?

Tools:

- Stakeholder Discovery Matrix
- Empathy Mapping
- Inclusion Gap Analysis
- Participatory Systems Mapping
- Personas and Stakeholder Journey Maps

3. PLANETARY EMPATHY

Focus: Environmental impact, planetary boundaries, material flows, biodiversity, systems thinking, regeneration

A. Lifecycle and Ecological Impact

Questions:

- What is the full lifecycle impact of our products/services?
- Where are the highest emissions, waste, or pollution outputs?
- What materials or processes are non-renewable, toxic, or high-risk?

Tools:

- Lifecycle Assessment (LCA)
- Scope 1–3 Carbon Accounting
- Environmental Impact Mapping (water, energy, land)
- Product/Service Lifecycle Visualisation

B. Material Use and Circular Economy

Questions:

- What raw materials do we depend on?
- Are these sustainable, ethical, circular, or finite?
- How much waste do we create — and where does it go?

Tools:

- Material Flow Analysis (MFA)
- Circularity Opportunity Mapping
- Cradle to Cradle Design Framework
- Circular Value Chain Canvas

C. Planetary Systems Alignment

Questions:

- Are we operating within planetary boundaries?
- Which planetary systems do we most affect or depend on (e.g. freshwater, biodiversity)?
- What ecological risks could destabilise our business?

Tools:

- Planetary Boundaries Framework
- Doughnut Economics (ecological ceiling and social foundation)
- Ecosystem Services Mapping
- Risk Constellations and Systems of Systems Mapping

D. Regeneration and Net-Positive Pathways

Questions:

- Can our operations regenerate ecosystems or resources?
- Where can we shift from harm reduction to value creation for nature?
- How can we pilot regenerative models?

Tools:

- Net Positive Business Design
- Regenerative Business Maturity Framework
- Leverage Points (Donella Meadows)
- Nature-based Solutions Portfolio
- Backcasting from Regenerative Futures

E. Systemic Risk and Resilience

Questions:

- How vulnerable are we to ecological shocks (droughts, floods, pandemics)?
- What interdependent risks exist between supply chain, climate, finance, and regulation?
- What adaptive capacity do we have?

Tools:

- System Dynamics Modelling
- Futures Wheel and Cross-Impact Analysis
- Polycrisis Mapping
- Resilience Diagnostic Tools
- Strategic Foresight Matrix